





UP IN ARMS (From top left) Actor Sreelekha Mitra; accused film director Ranjith; actor and activist Parvathy Thiruvoth

bers, and the Hema committee report had mentioned a 10–15 all-male 'power group' whose writ ran through the industry and ostracised those who did not fall in line.

Political pressure is mounting on the Pinarayi government. Left ally, the CPI, has taken a firm stand, with a party leader telling INDIA TODAY, "We have no sympathy for these villains in cinema, however powerful they may be." The state Congress and BJP too have stepped up attacks. "The government is shielding the accused. What kind of gender justice is the CM claiming?" asks Congress leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheeshan.

The Left Front government will find it hard to explain why it did not act on the report when the case comes up next for hearing on September 10 in the high court. New allegations are cropping up every day, but the hope is that the current outrage will lead to an industry clean-up. Speaking at the promotion for film *Thangalaan*, WCC founding member Parvathy Thiruvoth said, "There is a *keeda* (worm) in all the industries and we'll have to clean it up ourselves. But I do believe things are changing now. When we speak up for ourselves, we stand for everyone else." ■

don't want to be saddled with that burden.

All of which perpetuates a vicious cycle of crime and misogyny in the workplace. "Harassment," says Menon of Interweave, "starts small—with a pinch or a touch—and when not addressed, it emboldens the perpetrator. Do you think a rapist is doing this for the first time? No, he's doing it because he has gotten away with several smaller offences over the years."

Equally sceptical of companies' record on PoSH obligations, Krishnan says, "Unless there is unionisation in the organisation, PoSH committees will have the employer's own people on it, who will do as the employer wants done." She also believes that the provision to penalise the complainant in case of a false complaint should be immediately withdrawn as it becomes a tool to arm-twist the complainant and hence a big deterrent to seeking justice. The demand for the death penalty for rapists, too, is a double-edged sword. The conviction rate for crimes against women and children is not even 30 per cent. "The requirement for evidence increases with the level of punishment, which means the person may get away completely. So, we are saying that there should be some punishment, as that is also suffering," says Shah.

WHAT WE NEED TO DO PRONTO

Tejdeep Kaur Menon, former director general of police of the Telangana Special Protection Force, sees the solution in ensuring that women are provided basic facilities such as restrooms, safe and clean separate toilets, adequate security features and safe transport are provided and monitored. "The labour department must undertake regular investigations if these [norms] are being followed." She also advises legislation for CCTVs at the central and state levels. "Laws must be made on how many CCTVs an establishment must have, who monitors them, how long the tapes are kept, and ensure there is adequate lighting so that the footage is clearly visible," she says. Finally, Tejdeep cannot emphasise enough the need for more women police officers. "We have a mere 12 per cent of women on the force," she says. "We need more women to be a part of the police force and for conditions for them to work in this profession and feel safe to be improved. The presence of women police officers makes many women complainants feel safer and more confident to report."

Meanwhile, in the wake of the Kolkata incident, the Supreme Court on August 20 ordered the formation of a 14-member National Task Force comprising medical professionals and government officials to "formulate effective recommendations to remedy the issues of concern pertaining to safety, working conditions and well-being of medical professionals..." Earlier, on August 17, the West Bengal government issued guidelines mandating the setting up of separate designated restrooms with toilets for women, deployment of women volunteers at night, creation of safe zones for women with full CCTV coverage and monitoring, development of an app with alarm devices to be installed by all working women connecting them to the local police stations or control rooms. Extensive utilisation of helpline numbers is being encouraged, and security checks and breathalyser tests to be carried out in medical colleges, superspeciality hospitals